



LOVEBIRD · AGAPORNIS SPP.

Keep your lovebird the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: cage setup, the one-bird-or-two decision, a pellet-forward diet, egg-laying control, health triage, and the routines that keep a lovebird thriving for its full lifespan.

INSIDE

- ✓ Cage sizing and the bar-spacing rule that is a safety limit
- ✓ Food charts, a pellet conversion schedule and the never-feed list
- ✓ One bird or two, and what each choice actually gets you
- ✓ Health triage, a symptom table and fillable owner, vet and sitter sheets

48 pages

Intermediate

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) and feet (ft), with centimeters (cm) and millimeters (mm) beside them. A lovebird and its food are weighed in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows, and a bird's weight is also given in ounces (oz). Humidity, where it comes up, is a percentage (%). Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't bought a bird yet

Read pages 4 to 11 in order before buying anything. Two decisions are far harder to undo than the rest: the cage, on page 6, and whether you bring home one bird or two, on page 20. Settle those first, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 35 to buy once instead of twice.

If your lovebird is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist in the print list below, and go to the Red Flags page (page 27) if anything seems off. If the cage contains a happy hut, a nest box or a mirror, read page 7 today: those three items drive more lovebird problems than anything else an owner adds on purpose.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 33: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 40: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 34: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 41: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 37: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 42: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 38: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 43: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Lovebird advice online swings between two extremes: treating them as disposable starter birds, or copying care written for parrots ten times their size. Neither fits. This edition reflects current feeding, cage, light and egg-laying guidance, cross-checked against the veterinary sources listed on page 46.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian veterinarian experienced with small parrots. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book. Birds hide illness until they are genuinely sick, so find a vet before you need one. The Association of Avian Veterinarians keeps a find-a-vet directory of avian-experienced vets. Write the number on the emergency card.

Quick profile

Scientific name	<i>Agapornis</i> spp., nine species. The peach-faced (<i>A. roseicollis</i>) and Fischer's are the common pets
Adult size	5 to 6.5 in (13 to 16.5 cm); 40 to 60 g (1.5 to 2 oz)
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years typical, up to about 20 with excellent care
Native range	Africa and Madagascar: savanna, open woodland and forest edge
Diet type	Seeds, grains, berries, grasses and some insects in the wild; a pellet-forward diet with fresh food in captivity (page 12)
Cage, single bird	18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) at the least; 3×2×2 ft (90×60×60 cm) is the better target (page 6)
Cage, bonded pair	24×18×24 in (61×46×61 cm) at the least
Bar spacing	3/8 to 5/8 in (10 to 16 mm), half an inch ideal. A safety figure, not a preference
Handling difficulty	Intermediate. Beaky and territorial for its size, and the one-or-two decision on page 20 sets how tame the bird gets
Conservation status	Most species Least Concern; Fischer's lovebird Near Threatened, on the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature) list of threatened species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$130 to \$295 for the cage, perches, toys and cover, plus \$25 to \$50 for a first avian vet checkup. The bird itself is \$50 to \$150 for a common peach-faced or Fischer's, \$200 to \$400 or more for a rare color mutation, and \$20 to \$100 to adopt. Every line is on page 35.

Ongoing

\$22 to \$36 a month for one bird, which is \$260 to \$430 a year: pellets, fresh vegetables, replacement toys and the yearly vet check, averaged. A pair needs the larger cage and more of everything.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

A routine avian checkup runs \$25 to \$50. An emergency does not: egg binding or an injury can run into the thousands. Egg binding is the likeliest emergency in this species and it is a same-day problem, so an emergency fund matters more here than the price of any item on the shopping list.

Fun facts worth knowing

- The name comes from the pair bond: bonded pairs spend hours preening each other and sitting pressed together. It describes how they treat each other, not how gently they treat people.
- A hen lays eggs with no male anywhere in the house. It is not a sign of anything going right, and page 24 is about keeping it from becoming a habit.
- Lovebirds shell their own seed, so unlike some cage birds they need no grit at all. Offering it risks a blockage for no benefit.

The species, colors, size & lifespan

A genus of nine small parrots

Agapornis is a genus of nine small parrot species from Africa and Madagascar, living in savanna, open woodland and forest edge on seeds, grains, berries, grasses and some insects. The pet trade sells mostly the peach-faced lovebird (*Agapornis roseicollis*) and Fischer's lovebird, and the care in this package applies to both. Wild lifespan is not known, though it is likely shorter than in captivity.

Colors

A common peach-faced or Fischer's costs \$50 to \$150. Rare color mutations such as lutino, blue and pied, and combinations of them, run \$200 to \$400 or more, and exceptional individuals reach \$1,000. The care is the same for every color. Adopting a bird typically costs \$20 to \$100.

Size and lifespan

Adult length	5 to 6.5 in (13 to 16.5 cm)
Adult weight	About 40 to 60 g (1.5 to 2 oz), though healthy birds are reported up to 70 g. Your own bird's steady number matters more than any range (page 17)
Males and females	They look alike. Nothing about plumage, size or shape reliably separates the sexes, and only a DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid) test settles it (page 24)
Lifespan	10 to 15 years typical in captivity, up to about 20 with excellent care

A lovebird is often sold as a casual, low-commitment pet. Plan for the whole span: a decade or more of the routine, the cage, and an avian vet for every one of those years.

HAND-RAISED OR PARENT-RAISED

A hand-raised bird costs more than a parent-raised one and is generally the better choice for a tame, interactive pet; a parent-raised bird can still make a fine companion, but expect more work getting there. Tameness has a price: a University of Bern study of African grey parrots found hand-reared birds imprint on a person and are more dependent on people, with more aggression, feather picking and stereotyped behavior than parent-reared birds. It is a caution to weigh, not a verdict, and most hand-raised birds live fine lives as companions.

TWO SPECIES ARE IN TROUBLE IN THE WILD

Fischer's lovebird is Near Threatened, and the black-cheeked lovebird is Vulnerable across its small range in Zambia after heavy trapping in the 1920s. Tanzania suspended export licenses for Fischer's lovebird in 1992 after the trade drained the wild population. Captive stock has been bred on its own line since, with a blue Fischer's first bred in South Africa in 1957.

Cage size, bar spacing & where it goes

18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) is the least that is adequate for a single lovebird, and 24×18×24 in (61×46×61 cm) for a bonded pair. Treat those numbers as the least you can responsibly buy, and a larger floor of 3×2×2 ft (90×60×60 cm) as the target. Length matters more than height: lovebirds fly side to side rather than climbing, so a wide flight-style cage beats a tall, narrow one of the same volume.

	SINGLE BIRD	BONDED PAIR
Least that is adequate	18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm)	24×18×24 in (61×46×61 cm)
Better target	3×2×2 ft (90×60×60 cm)	Bigger again; the extra is length, not height
Dishes and perches	One set, perches never directly over a dish	A second set of dishes, and a second set of toys

BAR SPACING IS A SAFETY LIMIT

3/8 to 5/8 in (10 to 16 mm), with half an inch (13 mm) the ideal middle. The narrow end is the safer end, down to about 3/8 to 7/16 in (0.95 to 1.1 cm). Wider gaps let a lovebird trap its head between the bars, which can be fatal. Measure the cage yourself rather than trusting the box. Skip round cages, which give a bird no corner to retreat into.

Material

Powder-coated or stainless steel only. Homemade cages, cages with wooden components and galvanized wire all carry a real risk of zinc or other toxic exposure, and lovebirds chew constantly. The metals themselves are on page 10.

NEVER

Buy a cage in the \$30 to \$50 bracket. Cheap cages rust, and a rusting cage introduces a genuine zinc poisoning risk, which is a real veterinary emergency and not a minor concern.

Where the cage goes

- A room the household actually uses, so the bird is not alone for most of the day.
- Off the floor, at about eye level, in a well-lit spot out of drafts and away from doors and windows.
- Never in the kitchen. An overheated nonstick pan can kill a bird with no warning (page 9).

BUY THE CAGE BEFORE THE BIRD

Set it up before the bird comes home. A cage that is too small or poorly laid out on day one gets used as it is far more often than it gets fixed later.

Perches, dishes & what to leave out

Perches

Natural wood branches work better than uniform dowels for foot health, because a bird gripping the same diameter all day loads the same points of the foot. Perches run about 3/8 to 1/2 in (10 to 13 mm) across, in wood, natural branch, rope or concrete, with at least two in the cage and many keepers fitting four.

Sandpaper perch covers stay out of the cage. Place perches so that nothing sits directly above a food or water dish.

Dishes and liner

Exterior-mounted food dishes are worth the extra few dollars: you can feed without putting a hand inside the cage of a territorial bird, which is the commonest way owners get bitten (page 18). A plain paper liner under a removable metal grate is the simplest hygienic floor, because droppings fall through, the bird never stands in them, and you can read them every day. Avoid anything that holds moisture and grows mold. Lovebirds need no grit.

Furnishings checklist

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Perches of varied diameter and material | ☐ A foraging toy that hides part of the daily ration |
| ☐ Exterior-mount food and water dishes | ☐ Soft wood chew items, replaced as they disappear |
| ☐ Shreddable items: untreated paper, cardboard tubes | ☐ A plain, breathable cage cover for night |

LEAVE THESE OUT, DELIBERATELY

A nest box, a happy hut or any enclosed, tunnel-shaped tent, and a mirror. Nest-like furnishings are the most common avoidable trigger for hormonal aggression and chronic egg laying in this species, and a mirror can work as a mate. This is not a style preference. Unless you are deliberately breeding, they stay out (page 24). If you want the bird covered at night, a plain breathable cover over the outside of the cage does the job without the hormonal downside.

Toy safety

Lovebirds are aggressive chewers, so the toy list is stricter than for a calmer bird. Avoid small detachable parts, loose strings, open metal clips a beak could pry apart, and anything galvanized. Check the chew toys at every weekly clean: a toy worn down to a loose string or an exposed clip comes out.

Temperature, light & sleep

TARGET	°F	°C
Room temperature	65 to 80	18 to 27

A lovebird is comfortable at normal household temperatures, with no basking lamp, heat mat or thermostat. What it cannot take is a draft or a sudden swing, so keep the cage out of drafts and out of direct sun, where it cannot move away from the heat.

Sleep is a husbandry requirement

A lovebird needs 10 to 12 hours of uninterrupted darkness every night, at about the same clock time each night. Sleep deprivation is one of the recognized behavioral contributors to feather picking, and a lit evening reads to a bird as an endless summer. The cage in the living room is often the wrong sleep location: a cover blocks the light but not a nearby television or people walking through, so a covered cage may not give optimal rest. A smaller, plain sleeping cage in a quiet, dark room, moved to at the same time every night, solves both problems.

THE PHOTOPERIOD LEVER

A day longer than 12 hours of light is a documented risk factor for excessive egg laying, so protecting the dark hours is the first lever against it. For a hen already laying repeatedly, cutting daylight or room light to 8 hours a day, or 8 to 10 at the outside, can reduce the stimulus. That is a managed intervention to discuss with an avian vet, not a permanent setting, and it can take weeks to work (page 24).

Light quality and vitamin D3

Window glass filters out the UVB (ultraviolet B) wavelengths a bird uses to make vitamin D3, which lets it absorb calcium, so a sunny window gives warmth and daylight but not that. An avian-specific UVB lamp is worth adding if the bird gets no regular safe outdoor time. It runs 10 to 12 hours a day, mounted about 12 to 18 in (30 to 46 cm) from where the bird perches, and is replaced about every six months.

Signs your setup needs adjusting

YOU NOTICE	LIKELY MEANS
Standing on both feet, fluffed, eyes closing, sitting low or on the cage floor	Cold or ill. A fluffed bird is far more often sick than chilly, so treat it as a same-day vet call (page 27)
Panting, wings held away from the body, feathers sleek and flat	Too hot. Move the cage out of the sun and the bird to shade or cooler air
New plucking, with short or broken nights	Too little darkness is a contributor. Rule out medical causes first, then fix the sleep (page 30)

Household hazards: fumes & air quality

A bird's lungs move air in one direction through a system of air sacs, which is why a bird pulls far more air, and far more of whatever is in it, through its body than a person in the same room does. The practical rule: if you can smell it, it may harm a bird's airways. Smaller birds go down faster on the same exposure because they have less body mass to buffer it.

NONSTICK COATING FUMES KILL BIRDS WITH NO WARNING

PTFE, short for polytetrafluoroethylene, is the nonstick coating on many pans. Stable at normal cooking temperatures, it breaks down past 536°F (280°C) into gases that cause direct, caustic damage to a bird's lungs. An empty pan on a hot burner, or one preheated too long, can cross that line in minutes without looking scorched or smelling wrong to you. Sudden death is often the only sign. Irons, ironing board covers, some self-cleaning ovens and certain heat lamps can carry it too.

The fix is ordinary: cook with stainless steel or cast iron, keep the cage out of the kitchen, run the exhaust fan during high-heat cooking, and never run a self-cleaning oven cycle with a bird anywhere in the house.

Everything else you can smell

Aerosol sprays, hairspray, spray cleaners, spray paint, carpet fresheners, perfumes, deodorizers, votive candles, wax melts, essential oil diffusers and vaporizers all irritate a bird. So do plastics melted or burned in a microwave, and cigarette, cigar and pipe smoke, from the air and from residue that settles on feathers and gets preened off. Move the bird to a well-ventilated room before using any of them.

Smoke and carbon monoxide

Cooking smoke, a fireplace and carbon monoxide (CO) from any gas appliance are airborne risks too. CO is odorless and colorless to everyone in the room, and a bird sharing the air has no buffer, so it may be in trouble before a person notices anything. A working CO detector in any room with gas heat or a gas range is worth having in any home, and matters more with a bird in it.

Feather dust

Lovebirds do not produce anywhere near the dust that cockatoos, African greys and cockatiels shed, so the dust and lung concerns that come with those species are not a lovebird issue.

IF A PAN SCORCHES

Get the bird out of the house, open every window, and call an avian vet before anything else. Do not wait for signs.

Bird-proofing & the slow poisons

Before every out-of-cage session

- ☐ Windows and mirrors covered or blinds drawn: birds do not see glass as a barrier
- ☐ Ceiling fans off. A flying bird cannot see spinning blades
- ☐ Toilet lids down, sinks and pots emptied: most pet birds swim badly
- ☐ Doors shut, and nobody opens an exterior door while the bird is out
- ☐ Candles out and stove off, with hot pans cleared away
- ☐ Other pets out of the room: cats, dogs, ferrets and reptiles all carry a hunting instinct
- ☐ Lead sources removed: curtain weights, stained glass, Tiffany-style lamps, costume jewelry, old paint
- ☐ Countertops cleared of avocado, chocolate, onion and anything else on page 15

ANY MOUTH CONTACT FROM A CAT OR DOG IS A SAME-DAY VET VISIT

Cat saliva carries *Pasteurella* bacteria, and at a bird's body temperature it can multiply fast enough to cause fatal sepsis within hours, from a bite that may not even break the skin visibly through the feathers. Do not wait to see how the bird is tomorrow. A vet will usually flush the wound and start antibiotics straight away. Dog bites add crushing injury to the same bacterial risk. Supervised time is the real rule in a mixed-pet household, since a cat that has never shown interest can still react to one startled, fast movement.

Zinc and lead: the two metals that poison slowly

Zinc, sometimes called new wire disease, comes mainly from galvanized cage hardware, toys, chains and mesh. Chewing galvanized wire has caused zinc poisoning, because zinc can leach from hot-dipped galvanizing without the bird swallowing a flake. Electroplated galvanizing is considered safe, but hot-dipped, the more common and cheaper kind, is not. Early signs are stomach upset and appetite loss, then weakness, pale gums and discolored droppings. Powder-coated or stainless steel hardware avoids it.

Lead tastes sweet, which is part of why a bird that finds it keeps chewing. Signs range from weakness and stomach upset to circling, tremors and leg paralysis, and by then the bird is often seriously ill. Both metals respond to chelation therapy, a vet treatment that binds the metal so the body can pass it, if caught early, so walk a room for galvanized hardware, old paint and vintage glass before the bird has access.

Plants

A bird chewing leaves out of curiosity cannot tell a safe plant from a toxic one. Check any plant against a current toxic-plant list before it comes into a room the bird can reach.

Cleaning, bathing & hygiene

Daily

Take out soiled paper and discarded food, and wash the food and water bowls. A lovebird bathes in any water it can reach, so the drinking dish needs changing whenever it has been used as a bath, which is often more than once a day. Every bowl is emptied, scrubbed with soap and water, rinsed, soaked in disinfectant and rinsed again before it goes back in. Changing the paper each day also gives a daily look at the droppings (page 32).

Weekly: the full clean

- Move the bird to a travel cage in another room, so it is in a separate air space while anything is sprayed or scrubbed.
- Strip out the paper, perches and toys. Take every dropping and scrap of food off with detergent first, because disinfectant does little against organic debris.
- Disinfect with a bird habitat cleaner, or freshly mixed household bleach at 1:32, about half a cup per gallon. Most disinfectants need 5 to 10 minutes of wet contact. Never mix one product with another.
- Rinse in clean running water until no trace of the cleaner, or its smell, is left, and let everything dry completely before the bird goes back in.
- Spray the floor under the cage with water before sweeping, so dried droppings and feather dust stay down instead of lifting into the air.

A pair soils the cage faster, so the liner is changed more often than weekly when two birds share it. Perches and toys are washed and completely dried whenever they are soiled. Wooden perches, rope toys and nest material cannot be disinfected reliably, so after a sick bird they are thrown out. Only products formulated for use around pets belong near the cage.

Bathing

Offer a bath every day, in the morning so the feathers are dry before night. A dish of lukewarm water large enough to bathe in works, and so does a gentle mist from a plant mister for a bird that dislikes dishes. Plain water only, with no commercial bathing products, and bottled water if the tap water is chlorinated. Bathing keeps feathers and skin in condition and encourages preening, which matters most in dry indoor air, and it helps a molting bird work the sheaths off its new feathers (page 26).

WASH HANDS AROUND THE CAGE

Wash your hands with soap and water after handling the bird or cleaning its cage, and between any two birds. Psittacosis, which people can catch, is spread by dust from dried droppings, so dampen droppings instead of sweeping them dry (page 29).

Diet: pellets, seed & portions

A formulated pellet should be about 75 to 80% of what a lovebird eats, with vegetables and a little fruit filling the remaining 20 to 25%. Seed is the part keepers get backwards. It fails a lovebird for the same reasons it fails any parrot: short on vitamins, minerals and protein, and a bird eats selectively from a mix instead of across it, so the diet it actually eats is worse than the one on the label. It is also short in vitamin A and calcium, the two gaps this species runs into (pages 16 and 31).

COMPONENT	SHARE OF THE DIET	HOW TO OFFER IT
Formulated pellets	75 to 80%	In the dish all day. Small-parrot pellets
Fresh vegetables and a little fruit	The remaining 20 to 25%	Washed and cut small. Weaving it through the bars or hiding it in a toy turns it into a foraging job (page 14)
Seed	Measured, never free-fed	No more than 1 to 2 teaspoons a day. It goes further as a foraging-toy reward than as a bowl
Treats	A thumbnail-sized piece	A thumbnail-sized piece of any fresh food counts as a dinner-plate serving for a lovebird
Grit	None	Lovebirds shell their own seed. Grit is unnecessary and can cause a blockage
Water	Always available	Fresh and clean, with the dish washed daily. Changed more than once a day if the bird bathes in it

How much is a day's food

Pellets can stay in the dish all day, so the measured foods are seed and treats. To find what one bird really eats, weigh its food on a gram scale when it goes in, weigh what is left 24 hours later, and average the difference over seven days. That is its daily intake, and the amount to keep offering throughout a diet change. Weigh the bird too: losing more than 1 to 2% of its body weight in a week means a change is running too fast.

WHY THE PROPORTIONS MATTER FOR A HEN

A single hen lays clutch after clutch with no mate, and each egg costs her calcium twice: once for the shell and again for the muscle work of passing it. Where that calcium comes from is decided months earlier at the food dish. Seed is poor in calcium and heavy in phosphorus, the worst combination for the job, so the deficit builds instead of resetting (page 24).

Converting a seed eater to pellets

A lovebird that has only ever eaten seed may not recognize a pellet as food, and some will go without rather than experiment. That is the whole risk of a conversion: a small bird has almost no fat reserve and can go downhill in a day, so never starve a bird onto pellets, and never remove the seed dish outright and expect hunger to do the work.

SCHEDULE	HOW IT RUNS
Gradual, 3-day steps	75% seed and 25% pellets for 3 days, then 50/50 for 3 days, then 25% seed and 75% pellets until the bird is converted
Faster, 10-day taper	Start at 90% seed and 10% pellets on day one, 80/20 on day two, and so on until the bird is on pellets alone on day 10
If the bird stalls	Hold at 20% seed and 80% pellets until it converts rather than pushing the last step. Changing a bird's diet can take days, weeks or months

The limits that keep it safe

- A small bird should never go more than 12 hours without eating.
- Weigh the bird every day through the change, before the first feed, and write it down. A drop of more than 10% from the starting weight means stop and call an avian vet.
- Check the droppings daily. Minimal or black droppings mean stop and call a vet too.
- Check the tray to confirm the bird is actually eating the pellets and not just cracking and dropping them.
- Take the seed out completely only once the bird is reliably eating pellets and fresh vegetables.

Tricks that help

- Offer pellets first thing in the morning, before anything else, when the bird is hungriest.
- Grind pellets to a powder and mix it into a little moist food, then coarsen the texture and cut the moist food back over time.
- Scatter pellets on a flat surface for the bird to walk through and peck at, which can work where a new bowl does nothing.
- Keep a second pellet brand in the cupboard. A bird that refuses one shape or flavor for weeks sometimes takes another within days.

IF IT STALLS, OR THE BREATHING CHANGES

Weight dropping, a conversion that will not move, or a wheeze or clicking during the change is not something to push through on your own. A wheeze can be simple stress or a nutritional problem already at work, and only a vet exam tells which.

Safe vegetables, greens & herbs

Bright color is the shortcut: the orange, red and dark green vegetables are the ones carrying the vitamin A that a seed diet leaves out. Vegetables and a little fruit fill the 20 to 25% of the diet that is not pellets.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Bell pepper, any color	STAPLE	Bright, easy to chop, and an easy first fresh food to get accepted
Broccoli	STAPLE	Cut so the bird has something to work at
Carrot, and carrot tops	STAPLE	Raw, grated or in matchsticks
Sweet potato	STAPLE	Plain, with no butter, salt or seasoning
Kale and other dark leafy greens	STAPLE	Weave a whole leaf through the bars rather than chopping it, so it becomes a foraging job. Dark greens are also a real calcium source
Spinach, romaine, bok choy, asparagus	REGULAR	Good variety. Rotate rather than feeding one every day
Pea pods and peas	REGULAR	Popular, and the pod gives something to work at. Fresh or frozen, not canned
Watercress, endive, radish, parsley	REGULAR	Small quantities, offered as sprigs or pieces
Iceberg lettuce, celery	SPARINGLY	Not harmful, but nearly all water, so they fill a small bird up without feeding it
Onion and garlic	NEVER	Harmful to the blood. Never offer them, in any form. Concentrated forms like garlic powder or dry soup mix are the worst
Avocado, including guacamole	NEVER	Every part of the plant carries persin. Keep it out of reach as well as out of the bowl

PRESENTATION IS HALF THE BATTLE

Wash everything well, because pesticide residue is a particular risk for birds. Cut it into pieces a small beak can pick up. Fresh or frozen is better than canned, which carries salt and sugar, or freeze-dried, which carries less nutrition. A food the bird refuses gets offered again over 3 to 5 days before it is written off. Weaving greens through the bars, clipping vegetables to a skewer and hiding pieces in a foraging toy all get eaten more reliably than the same food in a bowl.

Fruit, treats & the never-feed list

Fruit is the smaller part of the fresh share: sweet, watery, and easy to overfeed. A thumbnail-sized piece of any fresh food counts as a full serving for a lovebird.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Mango, papaya, cantaloupe	BEST	The most useful of the fruits
Berries: blueberry, raspberry, strawberry	REGULAR	Well accepted
Apple, pear, grapes, kiwi, melon, peach	REGULAR	Apple and pear with the core and seeds removed. Peaches and nectarines are stone fruit, so no pits
Banana	SOMETIMES	Sweet, so a small piece, and best used as a reward
Apple seeds and fruit pits	NEVER	Apple seeds contain cyanide, and so do the pits of cherries, plums, apricots and peaches. Remove them before offering the flesh

Seed and other extras

- **Seed:** a measured treat of no more than 1 to 2 teaspoons a day, best hidden in a foraging toy so the bird works for it (page 12).
- **Dairy:** birds cannot digest lactose, so skip it.
- **Salty, fatty or sugary human food:** chips, crackers and processed food are out. They are not all strictly toxic, but they cause serious health problems.

THE NEVER-FEED LIST, IN ONE PLACE

Avocado: every part of the plant holds persin, a toxin that harms the heart. Respiratory distress usually shows about 12 hours after it is eaten, and death can follow within one to two days. **Onion and garlic.** **Chocolate,** which carries theobromine and caffeine, and **caffeine** in coffee, tea and soda. **Alcohol.** **Sugar-free candy,** which can contain xylitol. **Fruit pits and apple seeds.** **Peanuts,** which can carry mold toxins. **Mushrooms,** since some are toxic. **Rhubarb and nightshade leaves.** **Salty, fatty or sugary human food.** **Grit** is not toxic but is unnecessary and can cause a blockage, so it belongs here too.

Darker, more bitter chocolate carries more risk than milk chocolate, and none of these needs to be a dramatic exposure: a countertop within flight range of an out-of-cage bird is enough.

Supplements, calcium & the grit myth

A bird eating 75 to 80% pellets does not need a general vitamin supplement stacked on top. The pellets are the supplement, adding more is not extra insurance, and some nutrients cause problems in excess. Supplements are for seed-fed birds and for one particular case, the laying hen.

Calcium and the laying hen

Every egg draws down calcium: some goes into the shell, and some goes to the muscle contractions and nerve signaling that move the egg out. A hen laying repeatedly spends a reserve she has to rebuild between clutches, and on a seed diet she cannot rebuild it fast enough. Taken far enough, the result is a weak, lethargic bird with bones brittle enough to fracture in ordinary handling, prone to egg binding, and in severe cases at risk of seizures and death.

- Dark leafy greens are a real dietary calcium source and belong in the daily vegetables.
- A hen who is actively laying is one of the few clear cases for supplementing calcium directly, and that is worth arranging with a vet rather than guessing at.
- Vitamin D3 is what lets a bird absorb the calcium, and it comes from UVB light (page 8).

DUSTING SEED WITH VITAMIN POWDER DOES NOTHING

A lovebird hulls a seed and eats the kernel inside, so powder sprinkled over a seed mix rides out with the husks. The bird eats around it entirely, and the keeper reasonably believes the supplement is being taken. If a powdered supplement is in use, during a pellet conversion for instance, it goes on moist food, where it stays put and is eaten.

Vitamin A and calcium shortfalls

SHORTFALL	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	THE FIX
Vitamin A	Nasal discharge, sneezing, swelling around the eyes, conjunctivitis, labored breathing, increased thirst and urination, poor feather quality, feather picking and appetite loss	Pellets, and orange and dark green vegetables. Injected vitamin A is a vet treatment, not a home one
Calcium	Weakness, tremors, seizures, and fractures with no obvious injury. In a laying hen, thin-shelled or soft eggs	Pellets, dark greens, UVB light, and a vet's help for a laying hen

Grit

Grit is not part of how this species processes food. A bird that shells its own seed has no grinding job for grit to do, and eaten in quantity it can cause a serious gastrointestinal obstruction.

Weight, body condition & the daily scale

A lovebird hides illness until it is genuinely sick, and weight is the measurement that moves first. A bird's feathers hide body condition extremely well, so weight loss shows up on a scale days to weeks before the bird looks thin.

The scale

Buy a kitchen scale that reads in grams, not ounces: the swings worth catching in a small bird are often a handful of grams. A scale with a removable perch lets the bird stand on something it would land on anyway. Weigh every day before breakfast, at the same time, and write the number down. One reading says almost nothing; the logged trend says everything. Weigh daily from the first week to set the baseline.

MEASURE	WHAT TO KNOW
Healthy adult weight	About 40 to 60 g (1.5 to 2 oz), and healthy birds are reported up to 70 g. What matters is your own bird's steady number, not where it sits in the range
Length, beak to tail tip	5 to 6.5 in (13 to 16.5 cm)
During a diet change	Losing more than 1 to 2% in a week means the change is too fast. A drop of 10% from the starting weight means stop and call a vet (page 13)
A downward trend at any other time	Weight is the earliest signal of illness. A steady fall across several weigh-ins is a vet call even when the bird looks well

Body condition: feel the keel

The keel is the blade of breastbone running down the center of the chest, where the flight muscles attach on either side. Feel it with a fingertip; scoring is by feel, not by eye. Birds are scored from 1 (emaciated) to 5 (obese), and obesity generally means a bird about 20% over its ideal weight, or a score of 4 out of 5. This is not the 9-point dog and cat scale, which does not transfer to birds.

UNDERWEIGHT

The keel is a sharp, prominent ridge with little muscle either side. With a falling weight, this is a vet visit, not a feeding adjustment.

IDEAL

A subtle ridge, with muscle rounded out on either side of it. Not sharp, not buried.

OVERWEIGHT

The keel is hard to find because it is cushioned in fat. Usually a seed-heavy diet plus too little flying.

TRACK THE TREND

A keel that has gotten sharper since last month is the signal, more than any single score.

A rounded chest and a keel you cannot find is where fatty liver disease starts (page 31). It is corrected with a pelleted diet, portion control, and exercise through a larger cage and room to fly.

Handling, taming & the bite problem

The name oversells the temperament. Lovebirds are affectionate and bold, but they are very territorial and aggressive when frightened or threatened, especially hens and especially during hormonal periods, and a lovebird will readily chase a much larger bird, or the family dog or cat, out of what it considers its space. That does not make it a bad pet. It makes it a bird that has to be handled on its own terms, and a lovebird has to be handled daily to stay tame.

Taming, in order

- Talk softly and move slowly around the cage, and keep doing it until the bird stops backing away from you.
- Teach step up on a stick or dowel first: hold it gently against the bird's chest while offering a treat, so stepping onto it pays. A stick is safer and faster than a hand, and it gives you a way to move an angry bird without a fight.
- Do the stick work in a neutral room, outside the cage, where a defensive bird is calmer.
- Move to a finger only once the stick is reliable.

CAGE AGGRESSION HAS A MECHANICAL FIX

Most cage aggression is territorial, so the quickest wins are structural: remove any nest-like object, fit exterior food dishes so your hand never goes in to feed, and take the bird to a neutral room before asking anything of it. The aggression often eases away from the cage. Reaching into the cage of an already defensive bird is a reliable way to get bitten.

Where to touch

Head and neck only. Stroking the back, under the wings or around the vent reads to a hen as a mate's touch and encourages laying, so keep contact to the head and neck, and keep sessions shorter during a laying episode (page 24).

Where lovebirds sit against other small parrots

A lovebird is beakier and more aggressive for its size than a budgie or a cockatiel, and unlike a budgie it should never share space with another species: the pair-bonding drive that makes it devoted turns into real aggression toward a mismatched cage mate. It is also a more dedicated chewer, which matters when choosing toys. A bird handled from young is no harder than any other small parrot, but one that is not can be a difficult bird.

Body language, normal noise & when it is not

Small parrots have feathers, feet, eyes and a beak to speak with, and no single cue settles anything. Much of this rests on clinical experience rather than controlled studies, so the habit that pays is knowing your own bird's ordinary day, so that a change registers as a change.

WHAT TO CHECK	FLUFFED AND RELAXED	FLUFFED AND POSSIBLY ILL
Duration	Minutes, then the feathers sleek back down	Hours, or most of the day
Feet	One foot tucked up into the belly feathers	Standing flat on both feet
Eyes	Open and alert, or briefly closed mid-nap and open readily to sound	Stay closed, or slow and reluctant to open
Activity	Still interested in food, toys and people	Quiet, withdrawn, slow to respond
Position	Normal perch height, upright	Sitting low, or on the cage floor

A bird matching two or three items in the right-hand column, especially both feet down plus sitting low or on the floor, has moved past a normal rest posture. That is a same-day call to an avian vet, not an overnight wait (page 27).

The cues, one by one

- **Beak grinding** is a soft scraping sound a comfortable bird makes, often just before sleep. Hearing it is a reasonable sign the bird feels safe.
- **Eye pinning**, the rapid shrinking and widening of the pupils, marks arousal. It shows up around play and excitement and also around aggression and territorial defense, so a pinning bird is worked up, not necessarily happy. Reaching toward its face carries real bite risk.
- **Tail fanning** spreads the tail flat like a hand fan, briefly, with excitement. **Tail bobbing** pumps up and down with every breath and means the bird is working to breathe, a same-day vet call.
- **Head bobbing** can be impatience, or the prelude to regurgitating onto a favorite person or toy. That is a recognized affection behavior, distinct from vomiting, which comes with visible distress.
- **Crest position** does not apply: lovebirds have no crest to read.

Normal noise, and when it is not

Lovebirds are vocal at dawn and dusk, and that contact calling is flock behavior that cannot be trained away, only accommodated. You can reduce nuisance screaming by ignoring the noise and rewarding quiet; silence is not realistic. What deserves attention is a change: screaming that is new or louder through the day, pacing the same stretch of perch, or a bird that has gone quiet and still (page 30).

WHERE THIS MEETS WEIGHT

Fluffing says something may be off today. A downward weight trend says it has been off for a while. Run both checks together, never one as a substitute for the other (page 17).

One bird or two: the decision that shapes everything

Parrots are flock animals and need a social bond with something. A lovebird forms that bond with a person or with another lovebird, and once two lovebirds bond to each other you cannot easily undo it to get an interactive pet back. Make the choice before you buy.

CHOICE	WHAT YOU ACTUALLY GET	WHAT IT COSTS YOU
One hand-raised bird	Bonds closely to its person and becomes tame and interactive: rides on shoulders, steps up reliably, often affectionate	Handling and time out of the cage every day to stay that way, for 10 to 15 years or more
A bonded pair	Bond to each other. Entertaining to watch, busy, and largely uninterested in you. Closer to keeping a pair of finches than a tame parrot	A bigger cage and double the food and toys, and birds that are rarely tame or reliably handleable
Two birds, not matched	The risky middle: a pair that is not a true match can turn on each other	A second cage kept ready, and slow, supervised introductions

AGGRESSION BETWEEN MATES IS REAL

Aggression between mates is common, usually the hen bullying the male, and in a bad case it ends in injury or death. Different lovebird species fight when housed together. Triggers include a poorly introduced new bird, a cage that is too small and breeding-season hormones. When it happens, separate cages settle it, so budget for two cages from the start.

If you choose a single bird

No study has put a number of hours on a lone lovebird. What a single bird needs is set in days: interaction and playtime outside the cage, every day, not a long weekend session to make up for a quiet week. The risk is specific to this bird. In a survey of 2,331 pet parrots in Japan, lovebirds had almost seven times the odds of feather-damaging behavior that budgerigars did, and birds showing signs of separation anxiety were more likely to do it. The hours a bird spent with nobody home, and whether it had a cage mate, did not change the odds. A weekday has three pieces: a supervised session out of the cage, short training sessions folded into it, and foraging set up before you leave. A keeper who cannot cover the first on most days is the case for a second lovebird.

If you choose a pair, or add a second bird later

The second bird must be a lovebird of the same species. Size the cage for the pair from the start, and give each bird its own toys and foraging, since a cage mate solves loneliness, not boredom. Even two of the same sex usually bond to each other and become less interested in people.

- A vet exam for the newcomer, then quarantine in a separate room (page 23), where the resident can hear the new bird but not see it.
- Cages in the same room, visible to each other but out of reach, moved closer over days while both stay calm.
- The first meeting on neutral ground, in a room neither bird owns, both out and supervised. A hen defends her cage hardest.
- Separate cages again at the first sign of real injury. Squabbling is normal; blood is not.

Wing clipping & flight

A decision nearly every new owner is asked to make in the first week, usually by whoever is selling the trim. A clip is cutting some of the primary flight feathers, along the outer edge of the wing, so the bird cannot gain or hold altitude. It is not an amputation, it touches no tissue, and it grows back when those feathers are next molted out and replaced. Molt follows no fixed calendar, so check the wings, not a date.

THE CASE FOR CLIPPING

Reduces the risk of flying into windows, mirrors or ceiling fans, and of escaping through an open door

Can make early taming and step-up training more manageable

Some clipped birds are less brazen and more reliant on the owner

THE CASE AGAINST

Flight is the bird's main exercise. A bird that cannot fly loses cardiovascular and muscular conditioning that flapping in place does not replace

A bird that is more accepting of handling because it is less independent has not been trained, it has been made less able to leave

It guarantees nothing: a gust, an incomplete trim or regrown feathers can still lift a bird out of a door

IT IS NOT A BEHAVIOR TOOL

Clipping does not treat biting, screaming or hormonal behavior. A bird that bites out of fear before a trim bites out of fear after one, and is merely less able to fly away first. An over-clipped bird drops instead of gliding and can injure its keel or beak on landing.

If it is done, it is done right

Only fully mature feathers are cut. The standard trim takes four to seven of the outermost primaries on both wings, cut below the coverts that overlay them, and leaves the secondaries closer to the body alone, since those are what let a bird slow down and land. A heavier bird needs fewer taken and a lighter, more agile one more. Clipping only one wing is not recommended. A correct trim leaves the bird able to flutter down under control, not drop. Have an avian vet or an experienced groomer do it, and watch the first one.

A BROKEN BLOOD FEATHER IS A FIRST-AID SITUATION

A blood feather is a growing feather with a live blood supply in the shaft, and cutting or snapping one bleeds heavily in a bird this small. Apply firm, steady pressure with clean gauze, and put styptic powder, cornstarch or flour on the exposed broken tip of the shaft, never down into an open follicle, which can damage it permanently. If it has not stopped within two to three minutes, call an avian vet. Do not pull the feather at home: it leaves the shaft open and can cost more blood than it saves.

Whether to keep the bird flighted comes down to the room rather than the bird: how bird-proof the home really is, and whether you can supervise. Neither answer is wrong, and the decision is revisited at each molt (the room checklist is on page 10).

Enrichment & common mistakes

A wild lovebird spends much of its day searching for food, and a cage with a single bowl removes nearly all of that. Boredom in parrots is linked to feather plucking, repetitive pacing and screaming that goes beyond normal vocalizing. Enrichment comes after the right cage, diet, sleep and company, never instead of them. In this order:

PRIORITY	WHAT TO DO
1. Foraging	Hide part of the daily ration instead of serving all of it: pellets wrapped in a paper cup, or a foraging box the bird has to open. Parrots often work for food while a free bowl sits nearby, which tells you the work is the point. Change the method every few days so it stays a puzzle
2. Shredding	Untreated paper, cardboard tubes and bird-safe wood. Balsa and other soft woods disappear fast, so keep a cheap rotating supply rather than one expensive toy
3. Daily time and training	A supervised session out of the cage every day with interaction and play, plus short positive-reinforcement training sessions: step up, targeting, recall
4. Rotation	Three to five toys at a time, swapped weekly, mixing something to forage in, to shred and to chew. A toy that has been away a few weeks reads as new again

Reading the warning signs

Plucking, pacing the same stretch of perch, and new or louder screaming are the clearest signs current enrichment is not enough. In lovebirds the damage is often aimed at the thin skin of the wing membranes, so check under the wing, not just the chest. Lovebirds also get polyfolliculosis, several feathers growing from one follicle, which itches and can start feather damage on its own. The same signs can be medical, so a vet check comes first (page 30).

The mistakes that cost the most

- **A happy hut, nest box or mirror in the cage.** The most avoidable trigger for hormonal aggression and chronic egg laying, and it arrives packaged as a kindness.
- **Seed as the base of the diet.** The cause behind much of the health section.
- **Two birds, expecting a tame one.** A bonded pair bonds to each other. You do not get both.
- **One bird without daily time.** A single lovebird that stops getting interaction is a candidate for screaming and plucking.
- **The cage in the kitchen.** The most likely place for a sudden death from nonstick fumes.
- **Bar spacing chosen by eye.** A wide gap can trap a head.
- **Lights on past bedtime.** Too little darkness feeds both plucking and laying.

Enrichment does not stand in for sleep, a correct diet or daily contact with a single bird. A cage full of toys will not stop a bird plucking if any of those is missing.

Choosing a lovebird, quarantine & the first vet visit

Choosing the bird

Lifespan is the commitment people underestimate: 10 to 15 years, up to about 20. Hand-raised birds are already socialized and usually tame faster. A reputable breeder lets you see the parent birds, says whether a chick was hand-raised or parent-raised and when it left the nest, and answers questions about diet and any health issues without getting defensive. A shop is the easiest first contact but mixes birds from several sources, so ask how long the bird has been there, whether a vet has seen it, and whether new arrivals are kept apart from the floor birds. A rescue can hold adults with a known temperament, though ask about the bird's history.

A healthy bird is lively, alert and interactive, tracks movement and sound, and has smooth feathers. A bird that stays fluffed and still, sits with its eyes half or fully closed in the daytime, or ignores everything around the cage is not the one to take home, whatever the price or the selection.

Quarantine every new bird

A new bird can look normal for weeks while carrying something that would spread through a household in days. Thirty days is the floor, and the plan is 30 to 45 days in a separate room with its own air, while the bird is screened for chlamydia, salmonella, polyomavirus and psittacine beak and feather disease (PBFD). A household or aviary with several birds should lean toward 90 days, because an infected adult can shed polyomavirus intermittently for up to 90 days before clearing it. It applies even if this is your only bird now, since the second bird will need it.

- Its own dishes, perches, toys and cleaning tools, washed separately from everything else.
- Established birds fed, cleaned and handled first, the new bird last.
- Hands washed with soap and water between birds, and a designated shirt for the quarantine room if you can.
- No preventive antibiotics: doxycycline treats a confirmed case and is not a shortcut around time and testing.

The first vet visit

Book it before the bird arrives, inside quarantine, within one to two weeks of coming home. Expect a weight, a head-to-tail exam, bloodwork, a fecal check for parasites, a Gram stain for abnormal bacteria or yeast, sometimes X-rays, and PCR (polymerase chain reaction, a lab test that finds an infection's genetic material) screening for PBFD, polyomavirus and psittacosis. PCR can find disease in a bird that looks perfectly healthy. The Association of Avian Veterinarians keeps a find-a-vet directory; a vet who is a member in good standing is the minimum to ask for. Checkups after that are once or twice a year, and the first exam gives a healthy baseline to compare against later.

Sexing, hens & chronic egg laying

Lovebirds are a textbook case of birds that look alike: nothing about plumage, size or shape reliably separates a male from a female, and visual sexing tips are anecdote. A DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid) test is the actual answer, run on a blood sample or a plucked feather through a lab or an avian vet. Knowing the sex matters because a hen needs the management on this page, and an owner who assumes a bird is a cock will miss a laying cycle starting.

Why a lone hen lays at all

A hen does not need a male, or even another bird, to lay. Lovebirds are among the species that most often become chronic layers. Each clutch drains calcium faster than a hen can replace it, which turns a normal clutch into a soft-shelled egg, a fracture, or a bird that cannot pass the next one.

TRIGGER	WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT
Long day length	Protect 10 to 12 hours of dark. For a hen already laying, cut light to 8 hours a day (8 to 10 at most) on a vet's advice, then lengthen it back gradually
A nest site	Remove the happy hut, tent, nest box, and any dark enclosed place she can burrow into or shred paper into
A mate, or something treated as one	Remove mirrors and any toy she has bonded to. Separate a male into another room. Stop stroking her back, wings and vent
Abundant, rich food	Move fully to pellets and cut rich treats and surplus food
A secure territory	Move the cage to a different spot, which can help

DO NOT TAKE THE EGGS AWAY AS THEY ARE LAID

Pulling eggs one at a time keeps her body reading the nest as incomplete, so she lays more. Let her sit on the full clutch for a complete incubation, which for a lovebird is 18 to 24 days (the 21 to 28 days quoted for parrots in general is longer). Then remove the eggs gradually, one every one to two days, since clearing them all at once can restart the cycle. Hard-boiled eggs, frozen eggs or craft-store fakes of a matching size can stand in so no real egg spoils.

When the environment is not enough

A vet has options for a hen who keeps cycling: leuprolide acetate by injection, which typically halts laying for only 3 to 4 weeks and is repeated on a schedule, or a deslorelin implant, which can hold laying off for 3 to 6 months or longer. Surgery is the last resort. Both drugs buy time while the light, diet and nest changes take hold, and neither replaces them. A hen who is laying heavily, thin, and slow to bounce back between clutches deserves a vet visit before anything gets stuck.

Egg binding

The likeliest emergency this species presents you with, and one where hours decide the outcome. An egg that cannot pass lodges in the oviduct and compresses circulation and the air sacs. Small birds can die within a few hours of becoming egg bound. There is no home remedy that safely dislodges the egg, and no version where waiting until tomorrow is right. Lovebirds are named alongside cockatiels and budgerigars as the hens this happens to most.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MEANS
No egg passed in 48 hours by a hen you know is laying	On its own it is enough to make the call, before anything else on this list appears
Sitting low or on the cage floor, weak, not perching	A bird that cannot perch is seriously compromised
Straining as if to pass a dropping, a wide-based stance, tail wagging or bobbing	She is trying to pass an egg and cannot. This is already the emergency
A swollen abdomen, over-fluffed feathers	The egg, or the effect of it
Tail bobbing with each breath, labored breathing	The egg is limiting how far the air sacs can expand
An egg bulging at the vent, or tissue prolapsing from it	Late, and it does not mean the egg is about to pass. Same-hour vet
Cannot stand or grip the perch, or a leg that drags	Pressure on the nerves to the legs. It is compression, not clumsiness

What causes it

Calcium deficiency is the biggest cause, which is why an all-seed diet sits under most cases: a hen short of calcium cannot contract the oviduct hard enough to push the egg out. Obesity, a lack of exercise, vitamin deficiencies, hereditary factors, old age and an improper laying environment all raise the risk (page 16).

What the vet does

Heat, injected fluids, calcium and vitamin D3, and oxytocin to stimulate contractions. If the egg still does not pass, it can be removed under sedation, drawn out with a needle, or taken out surgically. Most birds treated promptly go on to live normal lives.

CALL THE VET NOW, NOT IN THE MORNING

Put her in a small carrier on a folded towel, keep her warm, dark and quiet, and go. Around 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C) is the recovery range for a sick bird, and birds recover and eat better at the upper end. Watch for overheating, which shows as panting with an open beak, sleek flat feathers and wings held away from the body. Afterward she needs rest from laying triggers for at least 2 to 4 weeks, and preferably a whole breeding season.

Molt, hormonal seasons & seasonal behavior

Molting

Birds normally lose and replace most of their feathers at least once a year, and many have a smaller partial molt about six months after the main one. A normal molt is slow, made of whole undamaged feathers, and never produces bald skin. New feathers arrive as pin feathers, each in a waxy sheath that dries and flakes away as the feather matures, which a bird works loose by preening. Molting takes a lot of a bird's resources, and the pins can itch while they grow in, so a molting bird is often quieter, touchier and shorter-tempered. Do not read the grumpiness as a training problem. Bathe or mist a molting bird regularly: the added humidity keeps the skin from drying out, may lessen plucking, and helps the bird work the sheaths off (daily baths are on page 11).

Molt, plucking or disease?

	FEATHER APPEARANCE	WHERE IT SHOWS UP	FIRST MOVE
Normal molt	Whole feathers shed gradually, pins in sheaths coming in	Scattered across the body	Bathe or mist, and let it run its course
Plucking	Chewed at skin level, ragged tips, or pulled out	Only places the bird can reach. The head is spared	Vet to rule out medical causes, then fix the environment
PBFD	Stunted, club-shaped or pinched feathers, changing symmetrically; beak flaky or overgrown	Includes places the bird cannot reach, like the top of the head	Avian vet and a PCR test; there is no cure

Hormonal seasons

Long days, plentiful food and a secure territory push a lovebird toward breeding condition. Birds under reproductive hormones are often less friendly, more vocal and more cage-protective and territorial than the same bird outside that state, and in the extreme, screaming and feather-destructive behavior follow. Regurgitating onto a favorite person or toy is a recognized affection behavior. This is the season to be least ambitious about handling and most disciplined about the triggers on page 24: protect the dark hours, take out nest-like objects, keep contact to the head and neck, and wait it out.

THE TWO-LINE SUMMARY

The first needs nothing, the second needs a vet and an environment audit, and the third needs a PCR test. Any feather loss that is not a slow, whole-feather molt is worth a call.

Red flags & finding a vet

CONTACT AN AVIAN VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

Lethargy or appetite loss · feathers held fluffed for long stretches, or sitting on both feet with eyes closing in the day · sitting on the cage floor instead of perching · tail bobbing with each breath, open-mouth breathing or wheezing · discharge from the eyes, nose or mouth · a hen straining, wide-legged, or with a swollen abdomen · bleeding · a change in droppings that lasts more than 24 hours · any mouth contact from a cat or dog · any shift in normal behavior.

Why "wait and see" does not apply to birds

A prey animal that shows weakness is the one that gets taken, so a lovebird conceals illness until concealment stops working. By the time a bird looks unwell to a person across the room, it has usually been sick for a while and has burned through the little reserve a 50 g body holds. That is why the threshold in this package is deliberately low: any clear deviation from that bird's normal is a call, not an observation to make again tomorrow. Tail bobbing in particular is a late sign. It means the bird is working to breathe.

Finding a vet before you need one

Not every small-animal clinic sees birds well. The minimum to ask for is a vet who is a member in good standing of the Association of Avian Veterinarians, whose find-a-vet directory lists members by location. Find one while the bird is well, and write the number on the emergency card (page 34) so the first exam does not wait on the search.

Normal versus concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Fluffing briefly while resting or settling for the night, one foot tucked up	Fluffed on both feet for hours, eyes closing in the middle of the day, or sitting on the cage floor
Loud contact calling at dawn and dusk	New screaming through the day, or a bird that has gone quiet and still
Preening hard, and whole feathers shed evenly in a molt	Bare patches the bird can reach, ragged or snapped feather shafts, bleeding skin
An occasional single egg from a hen that passes normally	Repeated clutches, straining, or an egg that does not arrive
Droppings with a formed fecal part, white urates and a small clear rim	Black or tarry droppings, bright lime green, or no droppings at all (page 32)

WHY DIET COMES UP FIRST

An all-seed or half-seed diet is deficient in vitamin A whether or not the bird looks well on it, so a vet asking about the food bowl before examining the bird is not stalling.

Psittacine beak & feather disease and polyomavirus

Two viruses, both best handled by keeping them out of the house. Both can hide in a bird that looks completely healthy, which is why quarantine and testing exist (page 23).

Psittacine beak and feather disease (PBFD)

Lovebirds are particularly susceptible. A circovirus attacks the fast-growing cells behind the beak and the feather follicles, so both grow visibly wrong. The signs are abnormal pin feathers and mature feathers that look stunted, club-shaped or pinched and change symmetrically across the body, feather loss in places a bird cannot reach, like the top of the head, and a beak that can grow flaky or overgrown. The virus sheds readily in feather dust and droppings. There is no cure and no vaccine, and most affected birds die of secondary infections once the virus has suppressed their immune system, sometimes within months, sometimes over years. PCR (polymerase chain reaction) can find it in a bird that still looks healthy, and a vet diagnosis is the only way to tell it from plucking, a bad molt, malnutrition or trauma to a follicle, and guessing wrong in either direction is expensive.

Avian polyomavirus

Lovebirds are among the species commonly affected when young. In unweaned chicks signs appear 7 to 10 days after exposure and include lethargy and a crop that stops emptying, and death follows within 24 to 48 hours of the signs starting. In budgerigars, mortality can reach 100% in birds under 15 days old, and many juvenile and newly weaned parrots die quickly with no signs at all. Survivors can show permanent feather dystrophy. Adult birds generally resist the disease but can shed the virus for up to 90 days before clearing it, so a healthy-looking adult is still a risk to a resident bird. A vaccine exists for selected psittacine birds. In the studied schedule the first dose went in at 35 days of age with a booster 2 to 3 weeks later, but an avian vet sets the schedule for your bird, its age and its exposure.

QUARANTINE EVERY NEW BIRD. THIS IS THE WHOLE PREVENTION STRATEGY.

A separate air space, separate dishes and tools, established birds cared for first, hands washed between birds, and a real vet visit with PCR screening for PBFD, polyomavirus and psittacosis. Skip any one piece and the others do not fully cover for it. Birds that have been to a show, fair or exhibition get the same 30 days.

Where exposure happens

- Bringing home a second bird without quarantine, the commonest route, and one that is easy to skip on the second or third addition.
- Birds from many sources sharing air and surfaces, as at a shop that puts new stock straight onto the floor.
- Feather dust, dried droppings and dander on your hands and clothing after handling someone else's bird.
- Wooden perches, rope toys and nest material from a sick bird, which cannot be disinfected reliably and are thrown out.

Respiratory disease & psittacosis

The category that moves fastest, in the animal with the least reserve. Watch for repeated sneezing, discharge from the nostrils or eyes, a change or loss of voice, fluffed posture, and a tail that bobs with every breath. Open-mouth breathing, wheezing and clicking are signs of a bird in trouble: an emergency, not an appointment next week.

RULE OUT THE AIR BEFORE THE BIRD

Before assuming infection, account for what the bird has been breathing: an overheated nonstick pan, an aerosol or air freshener, a scented candle, new paint, smoke. Fume exposure and infection look alike from across the room and are treated completely differently (page 9). Vitamin A deficiency can also cause sneezing, discharge and labored breathing.

Psittacosis, and why it matters to you as well as the bird

Psittacosis is caused by the bacterium *Chlamydia psittaci*. Sick birds and apparently healthy ones both shed it in droppings and secretions, so a bird can carry it with no signs at all, and some infected birds shed only intermittently. In the bird, bright lime-green droppings and urates are one sign, alongside respiratory trouble. PCR is the test, and a confirmed case is treated with doxycycline, typically for 45 days, because the bacterium needs a long course. A short course is not a substitute for quarantine, and a bird is not treated preventively.

THIS ONE IS ZONOTIC: PEOPLE CATCH IT FROM BIRDS

People usually catch it by breathing dust from dried droppings or secretions, and less often from a bite or mouth contact. Symptoms typically start 5 to 14 days after exposure, occasionally later: a dry cough, fever and chills, headache and muscle aches, which can progress to pneumonia. If anyone in the house develops them after contact with a bird, tell the doctor about the bird. Dampen droppings rather than sweeping dry dust into the air, and wash your hands after the cage (page 11).

Supportive care on the way to the vet

- Warmth, around 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C), in a quiet room. Birds recover and eat better at the upper end of that range, and a covered cage in the warmest interior room works.
- Quiet and dim, in a small carrier with a low perch or a folded towel on the floor.
- Stop adding heat if the bird pants with its beak open, holds its feathers sleek and flat, or holds its wings away from its body. Those mean it is too hot.

Feather plucking & behavioral health

Plucking is a symptom, not a diagnosis, with medical and behavioral causes that look identical across the room. Rule out the medical causes first, then fix the environment. Lovebirds are prone to it: in a survey of pet parrots in Japan, about a quarter of lovebirds showed feather-damaging behavior, against 4.9% of budgerigars, and adults were about three times as likely as juveniles.

The reach test

A bird can only chew, pull or over-preen feathers it can reach. Damage across the chest, back or under the wings with a full, undisturbed head is very likely self-inflicted. Feather loss on top of the head, where the beak cannot reach, is not plucking and points to PBFD or another cause. In lovebirds the damage is often aimed at the thin skin of the wing membranes.

Medical causes to rule out

- Vitamin A deficiency, which lists feather picking among its signs
- Infections, and parasites such as giardiasis
- PBFD, which looks identical to a habit at first glance
- Polyfolliculosis, several feathers from one follicle, which itches
- Liver disease from a high-fat diet

Behavioral causes to fix

- Boredom, and a cage with nothing to destroy
- Insufficient sleep, under 10 hours of darkness
- A cage too small to move in
- Sexual frustration and hormonal triggers
- Loneliness, or separation anxiety in a single bird

START WITH THE BASICS BEFORE ANYTHING COMPLEX

Cage size (page 6), 10 to 12 hours of uninterrupted darkness (page 8), a pellet-forward diet (page 12) and daily interaction and foraging (page 22). A surprising share of cases trace to one of those four. Add foraging before you add toys.

The other boredom behaviors

Plucking is one of three signals the same problem produces. The other two are repetitive pacing along the same stretch of perch and screaming that is new, louder, or well beyond normal dawn and dusk calling. Treat all three the same way: a vet check to exclude a medical cause, then a hard look at sleep, foraging, cage size and daily contact. In that survey, hours alone and having a cage mate did not change the odds; separation anxiety did. The aim is a lovebird that can settle alone.

DO NOT ASSUME A BIRD IS JUST STRESSED

Plucking always deserves a medical rule-out first, because an illness and a viral disease with no cure can produce feather loss that looks like a habit. Weeks spent rearranging the cage while an underlying cause goes untreated are weeks the bird stays unwell.

Nutritional disease, gut problems & injuries

Less dramatic than the last pages, and far more likely to be what you actually deal with. Most of this page starts in the food bowl or in the cage furniture.

Vitamin A deficiency and calcium shortfall

All-seed diets, and half-seed, half-pellet diets that are not portion controlled, are low in vitamin A. It shows as nasal discharge, sneezing, swelling around the eyes, conjunctivitis, labored breathing, increased thirst and urination, poor feather quality, feather picking and appetite loss. Seed is also poor in calcium relative to phosphorus, and indoor birds make less vitamin D3, so a shortfall shows as weakness, tremors, seizures and fractures with no obvious injury. The fix is pellets, orange and dark green vegetables, and UVB light (pages 16 and 14).

Obesity and fatty liver disease

High-fat food, meaning seed, nuts and table food, plus too much of it and too little exercise, leads to obesity, and fatty liver follows. Lameness and breathing trouble are what a keeper sees. It is corrected with a pelleted diet, portion control, and exercise through a larger cage, more than one feeding station and climbing perches. An overgrown beak is not a grooming problem: it points to malnutrition, liver disease, mites or past trauma, so it needs a vet workup rather than another trim.

Avian gastric yeast and the other conditions the species gets

Avian gastric yeast can leave a bird eating normally, with smooth feathers, and still losing weight. Whole seed or pellets in the droppings is a sign, and one fecal test can miss it, so a vet decides. Giardiasis, polyfolliculitis, poxvirus and so-called lovebird eye disease, marked by discharge from the eyes, depression and weight loss, also turn up in the species and need a vet.

Injuries

- **Broken blood feather:** firm pressure, powder on the broken tip only, never pulled at home (page 21).
- **Cat or dog contact:** a same-day vet visit even with no wound, because bacteria in the mouth can kill a small bird within hours (page 10).
- **Window or fan collision, a toe caught in a loose fiber or open clip:** a vet call, since a bird this size carries very little blood.
- **Nails:** there is no fixed trim interval. Rough, varied perches wear nails down. The quick, the blood vessel and nerve inside the nail, shows as a pink core on a pale nail and is found on a dark one by backlighting with a flashlight. Take a little at a time. If you cut it, pinch the toe side to side above the nail, press styptic powder or cornstarch onto the cut end, and keep the bird away from the water dish for several hours.

THE COMMON THREAD

Diet, sleep, light and an annual wellness exam prevent more of this list than any treatment cures.

Reading droppings, urates & hydration

The cheapest daily health check you have, and a small bird gives you dozens of chances at it: most pet birds pass a dropping every 20 to 30 minutes. Line the cage with plain white paper, change it daily, and glance at it at the same time each day, so you already know your bird's normal before anything changes.

One dropping, three parts

The **feces** are the solid, formed, worm-like part, green to brown depending on diet. The **urates** are the white to cream, chalky part, the bird's solid urine. The **urine** is the clear liquid ring around the rest. All three leave through one opening, which is why you see them together.

IT LOOKS LIKE	USUALLY MEANS	DO
Coiled green or brown solid, white urates, small clear rim	Normal	Nothing. Learn what your bird's normal looks like on the diet it eats
Red or orange tinge after colored pellets or a specific food	Food coloring	Nothing, if it tracks a food and clears
Lots of clear liquid, but the solid part still formed	Polyuria, excess urine. Often watery food such as fruit or cooked vegetables. Without a dietary cause it can be the first sign of kidney damage, especially from zinc	Recheck on the usual diet. Still watery, call the vet
Unformed, mushy solid part	True diarrhea, less common than polyuria and more serious	Vet, once it lasts 24 hours
Bright yellow or lime green urates, sometimes with lime-green stool	Possible liver disease or psittacosis (page 29)	Vet promptly
Black or tarry, or bloody	Digested or fresh blood. Lead toxicity can cause it	Vet the same day
Undigested whole seed or pellets	The gut is not processing food. Avian gastric yeast is one cause, even while the bird keeps eating	Vet, and weigh the bird
Very few droppings, or much smaller ones	The bird is eating less, or in a hen an egg may be obstructing	Weigh the bird. In a hen, treat as urgent (page 25)

THE 24-HOUR RULE

Once you know your bird's normal, any deviation that lasts more than 24 hours is a same-day call to an avian vet. Blood, black or tarry droppings, a bird that has stopped producing droppings near its normal rate, or any change with a fluffed, quiet or off-food bird does not wait the 24 hours. One noticeably larger dropping first thing in the morning is normal: it is the night's worth held over.

Hydration

- Fresh, clean water at all times, with the dish washed daily rather than topped up, and changed more often if the bird bathes or drops food in it.
- Note anything unusual with a date, or take a phone photo: one odd dropping described accurately is worth far more to a vet than a vague memory.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Cage at least 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) for one bird, 24×18×24 in (61×46×61 cm) for a pair, longer rather than taller (page 6)
- ☐ Bar spacing 3/8 to 5/8 in (10 to 16 mm), powder-coated or stainless steel
- ☐ Perches of varied diameter and material, none over a dish
- ☐ Exterior-mount food and water dishes
- ☐ Small-parrot pellets, and a fresh vegetable supply (page 14)
- ☐ Paper liner under a removable grate
- ☐ Foraging toy, shreddable items and soft wood chews
- ☐ Plain breathable cage cover, and no hut, tent, nest box or mirror
- ☐ Avian UVB lamp, if the bird gets no safe outdoor time
- ☐ Digital scale reading to 1 g, with a perch (page 17)
- ☐ Travel carrier, bought before you need it (page 39)
- ☐ Stainless or cast iron pans, and a CO (carbon monoxide) detector

Environment targets

TARGET	VALUE
Room temperature	65 to 80°F (18 to 27°C), out of drafts
Darkness, every night	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted, at about the same time each night
Light for a hen laying repeatedly	Cut to 8 hours a day, or 8 to 10 at most, on a vet's advice (page 24)
UVB lamp, if used	10 to 12 hours a day, 12 to 18 in (30 to 46 cm) from the perch, replaced about every 6 months
Diet split	75 to 80% pellets, 20 to 25% vegetables and a little fruit, seed no more than 1 to 2 teaspoons a day
Bath	Offered daily, in the morning
Weigh-in	Every day before breakfast, in grams, written down

Before your lovebird comes home

- ☐ Cage fully assembled, furnished and sited, before the bird arrives
- ☐ Quarantine room prepared if you already keep birds (page 23)
- ☐ Avian vet found and the first exam booked within one to two weeks of coming home
- ☐ Room for out-of-cage time bird-proofed (page 10)
- ☐ Nonstick pans and scented products out of the house, or well away from the bird (page 9)
- ☐ The pellets the bird is already eating, so any diet change can wait until it settles

Emergency & quick targets

CALL AN AVIAN VET NOW IF

Open-mouth breathing, wheezing, or tail bobbing at rest · a hen straining, wide-legged, swollen, or sitting on the cage floor, or no egg passed in 48 hours by a hen you know is laying · bleeding that does not stop with 2 to 3 minutes of firm, steady pressure · any mouth contact from a cat or dog, even with no visible wound · black, tarry or bloody droppings, or droppings that stay abnormal more than 24 hours · a bird sitting fluffed on both feet with eyes closing · a fall or collision · exposure to fumes from an overheated pan, aerosol or smoke · a steady fall in weight, or 10% down during a diet change.

READING	°F	°C
Room temperature	65 to 80	18 to 27
Warm, quiet room for a sick bird	75 to 80	24 to 27

READING	VALUE
Darkness every night	10 to 12 hours
Cage minimum, single / pair	18×18×24 in / 24×18×24 in (46×46×61 / 61×46×61 cm)
Bar spacing	3/8 to 5/8 in (10 to 16 mm)
Healthy adult weight	About 40 to 60 g (1.5 to 2 oz). Know your own bird's number
Weight during a diet change	More than 1 to 2% lost in a week: too fast. 10% down: stop and call
Quarantine for a new bird	30 days at the least, 30 to 45 planned, up to 90 for a household with several birds
Nonstick (PTFE) coating breaks down at	About 536°F (280°C), reached by an empty pan in minutes
Generator	Outside, at least 20 ft (6 m) from doors, windows and vents
Too hot: panting, sleek flat feathers, wings held out	Move to shade or cooler air, mist with room-temperature water
Routine avian checkup	\$25 to \$50

Your numbers

Avian vet _____ Normal weight, in grams _____
 24-hour exotic emergency clinic _____ Leg band or microchip number _____
 Bird's name and hatch date _____ Last vet visit _____

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Today's weight and the trend, the diet split into pellets, seed and fresh food, one bird or a pair and any egg-laying history, when the signs started and whether they are worsening, what the droppings look like, and anything new in the house: a bird, a candle, a cooking incident, a spray. Move the bird into a small carrier on a folded towel, covered, with the car quiet and not too hot or cold (page 39).

Budget & shopping list

United States retail ranges, September 2026. Every row adds up to its total.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
Cage, 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) or larger, powder-coated or stainless steel (larger for a pair)	\$80 to \$200
Perches and swings, varied diameter	\$20 to \$35
Shreddable toys	\$20 to \$40
Breathable cage cover	\$10 to \$20
Setup total	\$130 to \$295
First avian vet checkup	\$25 to \$50
All-in before the bird arrives	\$155 to \$345

THE BIRD ITSELF	TYPICAL COST
A common peach-faced or Fischer's lovebird	\$50 to \$150
A rare color mutation: lutino, blue, pied and combinations	\$200 to \$400 or more
Adopting	\$20 to \$100

EVERY YEAR, ONE BIRD	TYPICAL COST
Small-parrot pellets	\$70 to \$110
Fresh vegetables	\$80 to \$130
Toys, rotating	\$40 to \$70
Annual avian vet check and psittacosis testing	\$70 to \$120
Annual total	\$260 to \$430
Per month, averaged	\$22 to \$36

Only the lines above are priced here. Dishes, a gram scale, a travel carrier and an avian UVB lamp are also needed and are not priced, so budget for them on top. Toys are the wild card: lovebirds are aggressive chewers and go through them quickly. These figures are for one bird; a pair needs the larger cage and more food and toys.

PLAN FOR, DO NOT COUNT ON AVOIDING

Egg binding or an injury can run into the thousands, and an after-hours emergency clinic charges more again. A few hundred dollars set aside matters as much as any item on this list.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The cage. A cheap cage in the \$30 to \$50 range rusts, and a rusting cage is a zinc poisoning risk. Save on toys instead: cardboard, untreated paper and unfinished soft wood are free or nearly so.

First 30 days

Day 1

- ☐ Weigh the bird in grams and photograph it and the setup for a baseline
- ☐ If you already keep birds, the new one is in a separate room on separate air (page 23)
- ☐ Fill in the emergency card (page 34) and the equipment dates (page 42)
- ☐ Let it settle: food, water and quiet, with no handling beyond what care needs

Week 1

- ☐ Feed what the bird was already eating. Diet changes wait until it has settled
- ☐ Book the first avian vet exam for within one to two weeks, and ask about PCR screening for PBFD, polyomavirus and psittacosis
- ☐ Audit the cage against the checklist (page 33): bar spacing measured, no hut, tent, nest box or mirror
- ☐ Bird-proof the room for out-of-cage time
- ☐ Set a fixed bedtime: 10 to 12 hours of darkness

Weeks 2 and 3

- ☐ Start the pellet conversion if the bird is on seed, weighing every day (page 13)
- ☐ Begin taming: talking softly, then the stick in a neutral room (page 18)
- ☐ Start the owner log with a daily or weekly weigh-in (page 41)

Week 4

- ☐ Review the weight trend. A steady adult weight is the goal, and a downward trend is a vet call
- ☐ Check the fresh food is being eaten, not just shredded. Offer rejected foods again, cut differently
- ☐ Introduce the first foraging toy and start the toy rotation (page 43)

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Finish quarantine at 30 days at the least, 30 to 45 planned, up to 90 for a household with several birds, and only then share air and space
- ☐ Book any follow-up the vet recommended, and record test results (page 42)
- ☐ Watch for hormonal signs, especially in a hen: shredding paper, sitting low, nesting (page 24)
- ☐ Look back at the log for slow drift in weight, appetite or droppings
- ☐ Fill in the pet-sitter sheet before you need it (page 40)

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Straining, wide-legged, fluffed on the cage floor, no egg	Egg binding	Avian vet the same day (page 25)
Repeated clutches beyond an occasional egg	Chronic egg laying	Protect the dark hours, remove nest sites, see a vet (page 24)
Tail bobbing at rest, open-mouth breathing, wheezing	Respiratory disease, or fume exposure	Emergency. Ventilate, then vet (page 29)
Sneezing, discharge, swelling around the eyes	Respiratory infection or vitamin A deficiency	Vet promptly (page 31)
Bright lime-green droppings or urates in an unwell bird	Possible psittacosis or liver disease	Vet promptly, and tell your own doctor (page 32)
Clubbed or stunted feathers, beak changes, loss on the head	Possible PBFD	PCR test, and isolate from other birds (page 28)
A young bird suddenly lethargic with a crop that is not emptying	Possible polyomavirus	Emergency vet visit (page 28)
Feather loss only where the beak reaches, head untouched	Plucking, medical or behavioral	Vet first, then audit the environment (page 30)
Even feather loss on both sides, pins visible, skin covered	Normal molt	Nothing. Bathe or mist (page 26)
Watery droppings, solid part still formed	Polyuria, often watery food	Recheck at 24 hours, then vet
Black, tarry or bloody droppings	Bleeding, possibly lead poisoning	Vet the same day
Appetite loss, regurgitation, weakness, excessive thirst	Possible zinc or lead poisoning from cage or toys	Vet, and take a photo of the cage and toys (page 10)
Sudden collapse or death near the kitchen	PTFE fumes from overheated cookware	Ventilate, get any other birds out, vet (page 9)
New biting, cage defense, regurgitating on a person or toy	Hormonal season, or affection	Cut day length, remove triggers, hold off on handling
New all-day screaming, or pacing the same stretch of perch	Boredom, too little sleep or contact	Vet check, then foraging, sleep and interaction (page 22)
Rounded chest, keel hard to feel	Obesity and fatty liver	Diet change and daily flight, gradually (page 17)
Bleeding from a growing feather	Broken blood feather	Firm pressure, powder on the broken tip only. Vet at 2 to 3 minutes (page 21)
Fluffed on both feet, eyes closing, sitting low	Illness, or cold	Same-day vet call (page 19)
Weight loss between log entries	Several possible causes	Vet, and bring the owner log (page 41)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Fresh pellets and clean water, dish washed rather than topped up
- ☐ Fresh vegetables, with what is not eaten taken out before it spoils
- ☐ Change the paper liner and read the droppings before you bin it (page 32)
- ☐ Weigh before breakfast and write it down (page 17)
- ☐ A supervised session out of the cage, with interaction and play
- ☐ Offer a bath in the morning (page 11)
- ☐ Lights out at a fixed time, for 10 to 12 hours of darkness
- ☐ Quick check: posture, breathing, eyes, nostrils, feathers

Weekly

- ☐ The full cage clean, with the bird in a travel cage in another room
- ☐ Rotate the toys, keeping 3 to 5 in the cage
- ☐ Check the chew toys for loose strings and exposed clips
- ☐ Change the foraging method so it stays a puzzle

Monthly

- ☐ Check perches for wear and replace any chewed thin
- ☐ Review the owner log for slow trends, not just single readings

Every 6 months

- ☐ Replace the UVB lamp, if used
- ☐ Check the first-aid kit
- ☐ Re-audit the room for new hazards: a new candle, a new pan, a new plant

Seasonal

- ☐ As days lengthen, hold the bird's night at 10 to 12 hours with a timer or a sleeping cage
- ☐ Expect a hormonal season and a molt. Ease off handling, keep up the baths and the diet (page 26)
- ☐ Check heating and cooling have not put the cage in a draft or in direct sun

Yearly

- ☐ Wellness exam, once or twice a year, with any testing the vet advises

Power outages, heat, travel & transport

A lovebird needs no heat lamp, so an outage is mostly a question of room temperature and of what people start burning for light and warmth. A reptile keeper stops feeding when heat fails. For a bird the rule runs backward: a small parrot has almost no energy reserve, so food and water stay in front of it the whole time.

Do

- Keep feeding on the normal schedule, refilling by hand if anything depends on power.
- Move the cage to the warmest interior room, away from windows and exterior doors.
- Cover most of the cage with a thick towel or blanket, leaving a gap for airflow.
- Use a hot water bottle wrapped in a towel near the cage, never against it, in a genuinely cold house.
- For a visibly cold bird, hold it against your body under a loose shirt for short stretches.

Don't

- No candles, kerosene or propane heaters, gas stove or oven for heat in any room the bird is in. Use flashlights or battery candles.
- Run a generator outside, at least 20 ft (6 m) from doors, windows and vents, never in or near a garage, house or shed.
- Do not assume an open window or a cracked garage door is enough ventilation.
- Do not stop feeding.

The target for a sick or recovering bird is 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C), with a working CO detector in any room with gas heat, a gas range or a generator nearby. Carbon monoxide is odorless to everyone, and a bird may be in trouble before a person feels anything.

Transport and vet trips

- Use a travel carrier, not the main cage: compact, a solid or padded floor, and a low perch or a folded towel. Take loose toys and swings out first.
- Secure the carrier with a seat belt or strap in the back seat, away from an active airbag, and cover part of it with a light breathable cloth.
- Skip a water dish for the drive, since it spills under braking. A slice of fruit or a leafy green covers hydration on short trips.
- A bird is never left in a parked car, not for a minute. A closed car can climb 20°F in 10 minutes and 50°F in an hour, and a bird that lives indoors should spend under 20 minutes in direct sun, with shade it can reach.
- Overheating shows as panting with the beak open, sleek flat feathers and wings held away from the body. Move it to shade or air conditioning, mist it with room-temperature water, never cold, and call a vet on the way.

Leaving town

Feeding is the one thing that cannot lapse for a bird, so a sitter who has done a practice visit with you is the plan, with the sheet on page 40 filled in.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE CAGE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit, including an actual feeding and a cage check.

Bird's name _____

Avian vet _____

Age and normal weight in grams _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

My phone _____

Backup contact _____

Each visit

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Fresh water in a washed dish, and top up the pellet dish: _____ | ☐ Cover the cage at the usual bedtime (____) and uncover in the morning (____) |
| ☐ Fresh vegetables, exactly: _____. Take out yesterday's | ☐ Missed meals are not acceptable to skip "just this once" |
| ☐ Change the paper liner, and glance at the droppings before binning it | ☐ Wash your hands before and after the cage |
| ☐ Look at the bird: alert, breathing quietly, standing normally on one or two feet? | ☐ Use the exterior dishes. Do not reach into the cage |

Please don't

- Do not use a candle, space heater, aerosol, air freshener, scented product or nonstick pan in the bird's room or house while the bird is here. Fumes harmless to you can kill a bird.
- Do not let the bird out of the cage, and do not open a window or exterior door in that room.
- Do not add a mirror, a hut or anything nest-like, however cozy it looks. Do not introduce new foods or toys without asking.
- Do not move the cage, change the timer, or leave a light on past the usual bedtime.

Notes on this bird

Food and amounts _____

Quirks and warnings _____

Bedtime and wake time _____

Favorite treats _____

CALL ME IF

The bird stops eating entirely, sits fluffed and unresponsive, breathes with an open beak or a tail bob, is bleeding, or gets out, or if the room's power or heat goes out and cannot be restored quickly. If I do not answer, call the vet number above.

Owner log

Weight is the one number that moves before a lovebird looks unwell, and a bird that hides illness gives you nothing else to work with. Weigh at the same time of day, before the first feed, and write it down even when nothing has changed. Sixteen rows is four months of weekly entries, long enough to see a real trend, and it is the most useful thing you can hand a vet.

Equipment & vet log

Equipment log

ITEM	INSTALLED	REPLACE OR CHECK BY	DONE
Cage and perches, condition checked			
Avian UVB lamp, if used (replace about every 6 months)			
Pellet bag opened			
Scale batteries, and outage kit checked			
First-aid kit checked (twice a year)			

Twelve-month planner

TASK	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9	M10	M11	M12
Perch and toy audit	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Household hazard sweep	☐			☐			☐			☐		
UVB lamp replaced	☐						☐					
First-aid kit check	☐						☐					
Wellness exam	☐											☐

Vet visit log

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	REASON, FINDINGS AND TEST RESULTS	FOLLOW-UP

Record the PBFD, polyomavirus and psittacosis screening results here with their dates. A future vet, a boarding facility, or anyone you ever rehome the bird to will want them, and a negative result from three years ago is not the same as a current one.

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ 3 to 5 toys in the cage, mixing forage, shred and chew rather than duplicates
- ☐ Part of the daily ration served inside a foraging toy, not in the dish
- ☐ Perches at varied heights and diameters
- ☐ A bird-proofed room for the daily out-of-cage session

Weekly and monthly review

- ☐ Rotate the toys weekly, and put retired ones away rather than binning them
- ☐ Change the foraging method every few days so it stays a puzzle
- ☐ Two or three short training sessions a week: step up, targeting, recall
- ☐ Try one new safe food (pages 14 and 15)

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT

ENRICHMENT SAFETY

Check every toy weekly for loose fibers a toe can wrap in, small detachable parts, open metal clips and any galvanized metal. Replace shredded items before the bird works its way down to the hardware. And remember what enrichment cannot do: it does not substitute for sleep, for a correct diet, or for daily contact with a single bird.

Glossary, A to L

Agapornis	The genus of the nine lovebird species. Page 5.
Avian gastric yeast	A yeast, <i>Macrorhabdus ornithogaster</i> , that damages a bird's true stomach so it can keep eating and still lose weight. Whole seed in the droppings is one sign. Page 31.
Blood feather	A growing feather with a live blood supply in the shaft. Cutting, breaking or pulling one causes real bleeding. Page 21.
Bonded pair	Two lovebirds paired to each other. A bonded pair bonds to each other rather than to a keeper. Page 20.
Cere	The fleshy patch above the beak where the nostrils sit. Staining or crusting there can be a respiratory sign. Page 29.
Chelation	A vet treatment that uses drugs to bind a metal such as zinc or lead so the body can pass it. Page 10.
Chronic egg laying	Clutch after clutch of eggs beyond an occasional egg, driven by light, food, nest sites and a perceived mate, and hard on a hen's calcium. Page 24.
CO (carbon monoxide)	An odorless, colorless gas from burning fuel. A bird in the same air may be in trouble before a person feels anything. A detector belongs in any room with gas heat. Page 9.
Contra-freeloading	The documented tendency of parrots to work for food even when identical food sits free in a bowl, which is why foraging toys matter. Page 22.
Deslorelin implant	A hormone implant placed under the skin by a vet that can hold off laying for 3 to 6 months or longer. Page 24.
DNA test	A lab test of deoxyribonucleic acid, a bird's genetic material, from a blood sample or a plucked feather. The only reliable way to sex a lovebird. Page 24.
Doxycycline	An antibiotic given by a vet for a confirmed case of psittacosis, typically for 45 days. Not a preventive. Page 29.
Egg binding	An egg that cannot pass. A life-threatening emergency that needs a vet the same day. Page 25.
Fatty liver disease	Fat building up in the liver from a high-fat diet and too little exercise. Page 31.
Fecal test	A vet's check of a dropping sample under the microscope for parasites. Page 23.
Foraging	Searching for and working at food. Hiding part of the daily ration in a toy replaces what a food bowl removes. Page 22.
Giardiasis	A gut parasite infection, on the list of conditions lovebirds get. A vet finds it with a fecal test. Page 31.
Grit	Gravel some cage birds are given to grind food. Lovebirds shell their own seed and do not need it, and it can cause a blockage. Page 16.
Happy hut	An enclosed, tent or tunnel-shaped hide sold for cage birds. A nest-like trigger for hormonal behavior and laying, and not for a pet lovebird. Page 7.
Hypocalcemia	Low blood calcium. In a hen it follows repeated laying on a calcium-poor diet and causes weakness, tremors and fractures. Page 16.
IUCN	International Union for Conservation of Nature, which keeps the global list of threatened species. Page 4.
Keel	The ridge of breastbone down the center of the chest. Feeling it either side is how body condition is judged. Page 17.
Leuprolide acetate	A hormone injection a vet gives to pause laying, usually for 3 to 4 weeks at a time. Page 24.

Glossary, M to Z

Molt	The normal replacement of feathers, slow, with whole feathers shed and new ones already coming in. Page 26.
PBFD	Psittacine beak and feather disease: an incurable circovirus that damages feathers, the beak and the immune system. Psittacine means parrot. Page 28.
PCR	Polymerase chain reaction: a lab test that finds an infection's genetic material, so it can detect disease in a bird that looks healthy. Page 23.
Photoperiod	The daily light and dark cycle. 10 to 12 hours of darkness is routine, and 8 hours of light is the level used to break a laying cycle. Page 8.
Pin feather	A new feather still in its waxy sheath, which the bird flakes off by preening. Page 26.
Polyfolliculosis	Several feathers growing from one follicle. It itches and can start feather damage. Page 30.
Polyomavirus	A virus most dangerous to young birds, with a vaccine available. Adults can carry and shed it. Page 28.
Polyuria	Excess urine: a watery dropping whose solid part is still formed. Different from diarrhea. Page 32.
Psittacosis	Infection with <i>Chlamydia psittaci</i> , treatable with doxycycline, and transmissible to people. Page 29.
PTFE	Polytetrafluoroethylene: the nonstick coating on many pans, which breaks down into lung-damaging gases above 536°F (280°C). Page 9.
Quarantine	Keeping a new bird apart on separate air, with its own dishes and tools, for at least 30 days before it meets resident birds. Page 23.
Quick	The blood vessel and nerve inside a nail. Cutting into it bleeds. Page 31.
Styptic powder	A clotting powder that stops bleeding from a nail or a broken blood feather shaft. Never packed into an open follicle. Page 21.
Units	g grams, oz ounces, in inches, ft feet, cm centimeters, mm millimeters, °F degrees Fahrenheit, °C degrees Celsius, % percent. Explained at the start of the book.
Urates	The chalky white to cream part of a dropping, the bird's solid urine. Bright yellow or lime-green urates point to liver disease. Page 32.
UVB	Ultraviolet B: the light a bird uses to make vitamin D3. Window glass filters it out. Page 8.
Vitamin A deficiency	A shortfall from seed-heavy diets that shows in the airways, eyes, skin and feathers. Page 16.
Vitamin D3	The vitamin a bird makes under UVB light and needs to absorb calcium. Page 16.
Zinc toxicosis	Poisoning from zinc leaching off galvanized wire, toys or hardware, also called new wire disease. Page 10.
Zoonotic	Passed from animals to people. Psittacosis is the one that matters in this species. Page 29.

Sources

Veterinary references

- Veterinary Centers of America (VCA Animal Hospitals): the lovebirds general and feeding articles; fruits and vegetables in bird diets; bathing birds; chronic egg laying and egg binding in birds; household hazards and dangers to birds; zinc poisoning; nursing care for sick pet birds; veterinary care for your new bird; wing clipping; blood or pin feathers; abnormal droppings; signs of illness; psittacine beak and feather disease; polyomavirus infection. The cage floor, weight and lifespan, the 75 to 80% pellet figure, daily baths, the egg-binding treatment, and the 24-hour droppings rule.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: nutritional, reproductive, viral, digestive, mycotic and skin and feather diseases of pet birds; toxicoses; management of pet birds. Vitamin A and calcium shortfalls, obesity and fatty liver, PTFE, the 90-day aviary quarantine, and the four to seven outermost primaries.
- LafeberVet and Lafeber: the Basic Information Sheet for the Lovebird (weight, 18 to 24 day incubation, bar spacing, perch size); the chronic egg laying handout; body condition scoring; reproductive emergencies; grooming companion birds; foods toxic to pet birds; cat bites to pet birds; Susan Orosz, a veterinarian, on daily weighing; switching from seeds to pellets.
- University of Florida Small Animal Hospital: how to care for your pet bird. University of California, Davis, School of Veterinary Medicine: feather picking in parrots.
- Association of Avian Veterinarians: the find-a-vet directory.

Research

- Ebisawa, Nakayama, Pai, Kinoshita and Koie (2021), PLOS ONE: feather-damaging behavior in psittacine birds, a Japanese nationwide survey of 2,331 pet parrots.
- Schmid, Doherr and Steiger (2006), Watchbird: breeding method and behavior of adult African grey parrots.
- Turcu, Pastiu, Bel and Pusta (2023), Animals 13(3): feathers and oral swabs as DNA sources for sexing companion birds.
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Public health and safety

- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: about psittacosis, and preventing carbon monoxide poisoning. National Association of State Public Health Veterinarians and the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: the compendium of measures to control *Chlamydia psittaci*, for the 30-day quarantine with testing and the 45-day doxycycline course. Consumer Product Safety Commission: the carbon monoxide fact sheet, for the 20-foot generator distance.

Husbandry and species references

- PetMD: the lovebirds care sheet; egg binding in birds; getting a second bird. The 18×18×24 in cage, perch diameter, UVB lamp distance, and the introduction steps.
- Massachusetts Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals, Angell: the lovebird care guide. Bird Vet Melbourne: caring for lovebirds. University of Michigan Museum of Zoology, Animal Diversity Web: *Agapornis roseicollis*.
- Prices were last checked in September 2026.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Where credible sources give different numbers, this package prints one and says why.

TOPIC	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY	WHAT THIS PACKAGE USES
Cage minimum	18×18×24 in for one bird and 24×18×24 in for a pair (a pet-health reference); 3×2×2 ft (a veterinary hospital chain); 32×20×20 in per pair (an animal-welfare society)	The smaller figures as the least that is adequate, 3×2×2 ft as the target
Bar spacing	Up to 5/8 in (a pet-health reference); about 3/8 to 7/16 in (a veterinary information sheet)	3/8 to 5/8 in, half an inch ideal, the narrow end safer
Pellet share	At least 60 to 70% (a pet-health reference); 75 to 80% (a veterinary hospital chain)	75 to 80%, with fresh food the remaining 20 to 25%
Perch diameter	About 3/8 in (a veterinary information sheet); about 1/2 in (a pet-health reference)	3/8 to 1/2 in
Bath	Offer daily (a veterinary hospital chain); a few times a week by mist (a pet-health reference)	Offered daily
Adult weight	40 to 60 g (a veterinary hospital chain); 45 to 70 g, average 50 g (a veterinary information sheet)	40 to 60 g, with your own bird's baseline above either range
Lifespan	10 to 15 years, maximum about 20 (a veterinary hospital chain); mean 15, up to 30 reported (a veterinary information sheet); 10 to 12 years, oldest 17 (an animal-welfare society)	10 to 15 years, up to about 20. Plan for a decade or more either way
Incubation	21 to 28 days depending on species (a veterinary hospital chain); 18 to 24 days for the lovebird (a veterinary information sheet)	18 to 24 days
Room temperature	65 to 80°F (a pet-health reference); 60 to 70°F by day and down to 40°F at night (an animal-welfare society)	65 to 80°F (18 to 27°C)

REFERENCE

Version history & about

What changed in each edition, so a printed copy can be placed.

Version history

This is edition 3.0 (Oct 2026). The store page shows the current edition; re-download free if yours is older. Where this list and a page disagree, the page wins.

- **3.0, Oct 2026.** Rebuilt on the current outline, 48 pages. Safety: pellets 75 to 80% of the diet with fresh food the remaining 20 to 25% (was 20 to 40%); seed a measured 1 to 2 teaspoons a day (was treat only); no fixed hours a day for a single bird, only a supervised session out of the cage every day (was two hours); weigh every day, and a diet change that loses more than 1 to 2% of body weight in a week is too fast; quarantine 30 to 45 days, up to 90 for a household with several birds (was 45 to 60); a bath offered daily (was two or three times a week); sick-bird warmth 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C) (was 80 to 85°F). Costs: setup \$130 to \$295 and \$22 to \$36 a month, matching the cost guide's own rows (was \$190 to \$360 and \$25 to \$50). Other changes are wording only.
- **2.1, Sep 2026.** Safety: weighing moved from weekly to daily; a broken blood feather is handled with firm pressure and never pulled at home; incubation 18 to 24 days; the sick-bird warming figure matched across pages. Other changes are wording only.
- **2.0, Sep 2026.** Rebuilt, 38 pages. Safety: diet moved to 75 to 80% pellets; an itemized budget. Replaced by 3.0.
- **1.0, Aug 2026.** First edition, 21 pages. Replaced by 2.0.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the listed sources and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for an avian veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Treatments described here are for recognizing what a vet may do, never for use at home.

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